

Town of Hingham



HINGHAM CLIMATE ACTION COMMISSION

MEETING MINUTES

DATE: December 3, 2025

PLACE: Online via Zoom

MEMBERS PRESENT: Brad Moyer, Elliott Place, Jo-An Heileman, Lisa Hennessey, Doug Troyer, Matt Curran, Gary Tondorf-Dick, Tom Morahan

MEMBERS ABSENT: Alyson Anderson

GUESTS: John Borger, Brianna Bennett, Brenda Black, Paul Sprecher, Patricia Burke, Anita Ryan

Opening and Call to Order: Chair Brad Moyer called the remote meeting to order at 7:03pm. He opened the meeting with the required remote-meeting and recording notices, confirmed that the session was being recorded in compliance with Massachusetts Open Meeting Law, and welcomed members to the meeting.

Agenda Item 1: Climate Leaders Update: decarbonization roadmap and ZEV first policy

Brad Moyer reported that the Town submitted an application for a Technical Assistance Grant from DOER at the end of November. As DOER prioritizes communities that meet four of the six criteria for the Climate Leaders Program (as Hingham does), there is reason to be cautiously optimistic about our chances of winning the grant. Doug Troyer asked for clarification on the ZEV policy. John Borger publicly thanked the committee for their work.

Agenda Item 2: Discuss the Commonwealth's possible pilot program expansion for banning fossil fuels

The Commonwealth allowed up to ten communities to ban all new fossil fuel gas hookups as a pilot program beginning in 2022. The Commonwealth is currently discussing whether to expand this program. No decisions have been made. The question for HCAC is whether we would be interested in promoting admissions to the pilot program should it be expanded. Questions to be considered are how we would position ourselves for this initiative and what other initiatives we may have to put on hold (e.g. the Zero Emission Vehicle First Policy).

Jo-An Heileman suggested that being such an early adopter of the pilot program may be out-of-step with Hingham's municipal culture and history. Maria Zade asked how such a policy would be enacted. Brad answered that it would be a bylaw change. Maria responded that it would be good to know the timeframe for expansion. Will there be opportunities to join the program within the next 2 – 5 years? Paul asked how retrofits of old buildings would factor into the pilot program and the costs to the Town. He also wondered what incentives and grants come with admission to the program.

Brenda pointed out that the ZEV policy would not need Town Meeting approval while pilot program entry would. John Borger would like to know what the current rate of new construction gas hookups in the Town is and whether it is more commercial or residential. That information will help us to understand how impactful entry into this program could be.

The committee decided that it would choose members to reach out to communities that are currently in the pilot program. Patricia Burke and Maria Zade will try to speak with officials in Lexington and Acton about their experience and report back. Patricia will also try to reach out to other communities. John Borger offered to speak with Zero Carbon MA, one of the proponents of the program, and report back. Committee members and guests will report back to the full committee within the next 2-3 meetings.

Agenda Item 3: Solar net-metering/payback for residential solar installations that contribute to the grid

Solar net-metering/payback allows HMLP to pay solar panel homeowners for excess energy produced. As some members of the Hingham Light Board are considered "early adopters" of solar panels, voting in favor of such a policy is seen as a conflict of interest per the State Ethics Board. The Light Board is further restricted from setting rates that would affect less than 10% of the community, which would be the case with setting rates for solar panel homes in Hingham. The question is how we can support adoption of solar panels in Hingham given that the Light Board is currently restricted from offering incentives for excess energy produced. Brad asked if the HCAC could be considered an impartial advisor whose opinion would allow the Light Board to support this policy (or not). One option is to petition the State Ethics Board to reconsider their decision as the policy is inadvertently punishing the Town for electing progressive board members. Brad offered to discuss with the Light Board what role HCAC may be able to have with petitioning the State Ethics Board.

Agenda Item 4: Opportunities for engagement on public projects

a. [Hingham Housing Authority Beal Street senior units](#)

This is a large multiunit housing project being proposed in West Hingham. HCAC can watch and be present at these meetings to try to ensure that the Town's climate goals are being considered. Lisa Hennessey and Matt Curran volunteered to keep tabs on this project. Anita Ryan (37 Baker Hill Dr) shared that there used to be an ammunition depot at the proposed site and she hopes that the new building will follow the existing concrete footprint and minimize disturbance of the forest. Doug Troyer pointed out the Conservation Commission will need to give approval as there are several protected areas on the site.

b. Library HVAC replacement

In early November, the Select Board approved an agreement with Allied Consulting Engineering Services to design a replacement for the town library's failing HVAC chiller system, authorizing up to \$80,000 in funding for the engineering work. The total capital project is likely to exceed \$580,000. This is another opportunity to get in from the early stages and be sure that the Climate Action Plan is upheld. Jo-An volunteered to keep watch on this project.

Agenda Item 5: Warrant article submission and follow-on processes

The warrant article for dissolution of the EAC and reconfiguration of the HCAC has been submitted. Next steps are to plan socialization and an Advisory Committee presentation.

Agenda Item 6: Review and approve the minutes from the previous meeting

The minutes were approved.

Agenda Item 7: Other business brought before the Commission

John Borger shared that Hingham Net Zero is discussing adoption of heat pumps within Hingham, especially in homes transitioning from oil. The transition rate (from all types of homes) is lower than hoped for. HNZ is considering options to reach beyond early adopters. They are also looking at ways to get better data about homes that are likely candidates for conversion with the goal of targeting outreach to those homes. HCAC members discussed how we could support such an effort.

Agenda Item 8: Adjourn at 8:40 pm

Next Meeting: January 7, 2026